

URLs, Slugs, and Navigation

A minor ranking signal that is expensive to change, which makes getting it right early worth more than it looks.

Bottom line

URL structure is a small direct signal and a large indirect one. It shapes crawl priority, it is what people see and copy, and it is the one on-page element where changing your mind later costs real traffic. Set the pattern deliberately, then leave existing URLs alone.

The rules

Short. Under **60 characters** where practical. [practitioner]

Lowercase. Some servers treat /Page and /page as different URLs, which creates duplicates you did not intend.

Hyphens, never underscores. Google treats hyphens as word separators and underscores as joiners. seo_audit_guide reads as one token, seo-audit-guide reads as three words.

The main term, once. /blog/seo-audit-guide not
/blog/seo-audit-guide-seo-checklist-seo-tips.

No dates for evergreen content. /2024/03/seo-guide tells everyone the piece is old and makes updating awkward. Dates belong on news, not on guides.

No parameters where a clean path will do. ?id=4471 is opaque to readers and creates canonical work you do not need.

Flat hierarchy, three levels maximum. /services/seo-audit beats
/services/marketing/search/audits/technical/seo-audit. Depth costs crawl priority, which is Section 25.

The rule that saves you the most pain

Do not change existing URLs to optimize them.

A URL change means a redirect, which means: some signal loss through the redirect, every internal link to update, every external link now pointing at a redirect, social shares pointing at the old URL, and a window where things behave oddly.

Weigh that against the gain, which is a minor ranking signal. The maths almost never works.

When a URL change is justified:

- The URL is genuinely broken or misleading
- You are restructuring the site anyway, so the redirect cost is already being paid
- The URL contains something you must remove, such as a wrong brand name or a discontinued product
- A migration is happening for other reasons

When it is not justified: the slug is not quite the keyword you now target, or somebody wants it tidier.

If you do change one, 301 the old URL, update every internal link to point at the new one directly rather than through the redirect, and expect a settling period. Section 24 covers the mechanics.

Navigation labels

Navigation is where URL thinking meets user thinking, and the two pull in different directions.

Use the words your customers use, not your internal vocabulary. If your team says "engagements" and customers say "projects", the nav says projects. Your Section 6 first-party research is the source for this: real phrasing from real buyers.

Navigation links are strong internal links. Anything in the main nav gets linked from every page, which concentrates authority on it. That means the nav is a statement about what matters on your site. A nav with fifteen items says nothing matters.

Keep primary nav to about seven items. More than that and both people and crawl priority get diluted.

Breadcrumbs earn their place. They give readers orientation, they reinforce hierarchy for crawlers, and with BreadcrumbList schema they make the structure machine-readable independently of your prose. That schema type is described as one of the most under-implemented signals available, and Section 30 covers it. [practitioner]

Common structural mistakes

Category pages that are just lists of links with no content of their own. These are thin by default and rarely rank. Give a category page a genuine introduction that establishes what the category covers.

Every page one click from the homepage. Sounds good, produces a flat mess with no hierarchy and a nav nobody can scan.

Orphan pages. Published, never linked from anywhere. From Section 2, these are effectively invisible. Every page needs at least one internal link pointing at it.

Parallel structures. /services/seo and /seo-services both existing is cannibalization with extra steps.

Why this matters

URLs are the one on-page element with a real switching cost. Titles can be rewritten weekly at no risk. A URL changed carelessly costs traffic and creates maintenance forever. Decide the pattern once, apply it to new pages, and resist tidying old ones.

Do this now

- 1 **Write down your URL pattern** as a rule: what a service page looks like, what a blog post looks like, what a location page looks like.
- 2 **Check your existing URLs against it.** List which do not comply.
- 3 **For each non-compliant URL, decide: leave it.** Unless it is genuinely broken or misleading. Write the reason next to any you decide to change.
- 4 **Check for parallel structures.** Search `site:yourdomain.com` and look for two URLs covering the same thing.
- 5 **Audit your main navigation.** Count the items. Are the labels your customers' words or yours? Is anything in there that does not deserve a link from every page?
- 6 **Find orphan pages.** In Search Console, look for indexed URLs that receive no internal links, or crawl the site with Screaming Frog's free tier and check the orphan report.
- 7 **Add internal links to any orphans worth keeping.** Delete or redirect the rest.

Capstone step

You have a documented URL pattern for new pages, a deliberate decision to leave existing URLs alone unless genuinely broken, a navigation audited against customer vocabulary, and orphan pages either linked or removed.

Key takeaways

- Short, lowercase, hyphenated, main term once, three levels maximum, no dates on evergreen content.
- Do not change existing URLs to optimize them. The signal gain is minor and the redirect and maintenance cost is real.
- Navigation labels should use customer vocabulary, and everything in the main nav gets linked from every page, so a fifteen-item nav says nothing matters.
- Orphan pages are effectively invisible. Every page worth keeping needs at least one internal link pointing at it.

